

DUST OF SNOW

Central Idea of the Poem

The 'Dust of Snow' by Robert Frost is a small and simple poem with a deep meaning. It expresses the significance of small things in changing one's attitude. The poem reiterates that the little things in life can make huge changes in our future. It also shows that if we take the hard times of life in stride eventually something will happen to change our situation into happier times.

Themes

Dust of Snow has as its main themes:

1. communication between nature and humans.
2. nature healing and helping with negative human emotions.
3. the significance of small natural events

Questions/Answers

Q1. What is a "dust of snow"? What does the poet say has changed his mood? How has the poet's mood changed?

A. "Dust of snow" refers to the tiny particles of snow. The particles are so small that poet referred to them as "dust". The poet was in an awful mood when particles of snow had fallen on him. This changed the poet's frame of mind instantly and his day got a lot better.

Q 2. How does Frost present nature in this poem? The following questions may help you to think of an answer.

(i) What are the birds that are usually named in poems? Do you think a crow is often mentioned in poems? What images come to your mind when you think of a crow?

A. Birds like sparrow, nightingale and peacock are more than often named in poems. Unlike these birds, crows are often seen as the indicators of doom and fear. They are often used for negative references.

(ii) Again, what is "a hemlock tree"? Why doesn't the poet write about a more 'beautiful' tree such as a maple, or an oak, or a pine?

A. Trees are also seen as mighty creatures imparting wisdom as they're too old. They give out oxygen and absorb the carbon dioxide which is connected with absorbing all the negative energy. But there are trees that are poisonous too, like a hemlock tree. The poet does not mention a more 'beautiful' tree such as maple, oak or pine because he wants to indicate a sad scene. Being poisonous, a hemlock tree is considered bad and so, he refers to it.

(iii) What do the 'crow' and 'hemlock' represent — joy or sorrow? What does the dust of snow that the crow shakes off a hemlock tree stand for?

A. Both crow and the hemlock tree represent sorrow. Frost has used both the negative creatures (crow and the hemlock tree) as the carriers of positivism and strength that transformed his day for the better. By not using birds like sparrow and nightingale and trees like maple, oak or a pine, the poet has tried to break down all the preconceived notions we have about certain agents of nature. He has tried to make us understand that we see the world not as how it is, but as how we want to see it. Thus, the crow sitting and a hemlock tree together made his day better. The dust of snow stands for joy.

Home Assignment

Week: - 5

Class: - 10/B

Subject:-English

Dust of Snow
By Robert Frost

Central idea of the poem

The central idea of the poem Dust and Snow written by Robert Frost is that one may have the worst day or time of his life, but a little good thing can make it quite amazing. The crow, the hemlock tree and the dust are some bad signs that normally make the people believe that something wrong is going to happen.

The poet in the poem, I think, is already upset. This is why he comes out of his home to wander in the snow. But a crow shakes and snow falls on him which makes him happy.

The poem gives us the message that one should hope for the best even in the worst. Like negative and negative makes positive in mathematics, similarly, in real life, we can make enjoy in our worst times.

Explanation of the poem:-

Stanza-1

*The way a crow
Shook down on me
The dust of snow
From a hemlock tree*

The poem is set in a scene where the poet is in a bad mood and is walking by a tree, a hemlock tree. Hemlock tree is a poisonous tree. As he passes by, a crow happens to throw some snow dust on him. Whether it falls on his head or shoulders is unknown as there is no specific mention in the poem. Also, the readers are left in doubt about the bird's specific action. Whether the crow was landing, shivering with cold, re adjusting itself on the branch or taking off, it happened to send some particles of snow upon the author. Here, the two agents of nature, the hemlock tree and the crow are signifiers of sadness and gloom just like the poet's mood was in the opening scene.

Stanza-2

*Has given my heart
A change of mood
And saved some part
Of a day I had rued.*

For reasons unknown, the author was having a terrible day. But the falling of the snow on his head lifted his mood instantly. He had already spent his day in a bad mood but the rest of it was saved by the crow and the hemlock tree. Generally, hemlock tree and crow are used for negative references but the poet used them beautifully to portray that inauspicious things can bring joy and happiness too. One must not take things for granted and should be open and accept whichever way the nature chooses to bless us.

Literary Devices

1. **Rhyme Scheme**- abab cdcd
2. **Alliteration**- the occurrence of the same letter or sound at the beginning of adjacent or closely connected words.
 - The instances of alliteration are as follows-
Has given my **h**ear**t**
And **s**aved **s**ome **p**ar**t**
3. **Inversion** - when the structure of a sentence is changed by the poet to create rhyme, this poetic license is called inversion. In stanza 1, inversion can be seen.
4. **Assonance** - the prominence of a vowel sound throughout a line is called assonance. In stanza 1, line 2 - “Shook down on me” - ‘o’ sound is prominent.
5. **Enjambment** - when the same sentence continues to the next line without the use of any punctuation marks, it is called enjambment. It has been used throughout the poem.

Read the extract and answer the questions:

The way a crow
Shook down on me
The dust of snow
From a hemlock tree
Has given my heart
A change of mood
And saved some part
Of a day I had rued.

- (a) What do the 'crow' and 'hemlock' symbolise?
- (b) The mood of the poet changed because_____.
- (c) What does the poet mean when he says and saved some part of the day?
- (d) Who shook the dust of snow?
- (e) What is the dust of snow?
- (f) What mood of the poet is conveyed in these lines?
- (g) What did the crow do to the hemlock tree?
- (h) What did the tree have on it then?

Short answer type questions:-

1. What happened when the "Dust of Snow" fell on the poet?
2. Who was the writer (Poet) of the "Dust of Snow" Poem?
3. What happened to the poet's mood when a close looks down on him?
Or, how does the cross change the poet's mood?
4. How was the poet's day before that incidence?
5. What was the good thing that happens at last with the poet?